

BEFORE

Long before the Vikings spread across the continent, Europe had experienced raids by outsiders and established trade links with the east.

FLOCKING TO AN EMPIRE

In the 5th century many different peoples moved from farther east to trade, and often to settle in the relative **safety and prosperity** of the Roman Empire << 110–13.

PEOPLE PRESSURE

During the 4th and 5th centuries BCE immigrants arrived in such numbers that they destabilized a Roman world already in crisis << 150–51.



ROMULUS
AUGUSTUS

BREAKING UP THE EMPIRE

The Roman empire in Western Europe ended when the boy-emperor, Romulus Augustus, was deposed by his own general, Odoacer, in 476 << 150–51. Without Rome's protection, many **small kingdoms, principalities, and lordships** were now more vulnerable to raiders.



Viking war helmet

Viking helmets were similar to those used by other cultures at this time. The myth that their helmets had horns attached to them probably came about because Vikings were often compared to demons and devils.

HOW WE KNOW

ARABIC DIRHAMS

The Vikings raided and traded across an enormous geographical area. We know this through the types of coins found at Viking sites, in graves, and connected to towns. This 9th century hoard of Arabic dirhams was found at a Viking site in Scotland, and provides proof that Scandinavians sailed from the Baltic and along the rivers of Russia to reach the economic spheres of both Byzantium (see pp.198–99) and the Islamic caliphate (see pp.174–77). Arabic coins of a similar date have also been found at Viking trading centers at Birka in Sweden and Hedeby, Denmark.



There is a great deal of debate about why warriors from Denmark, Norway, and Sweden left their homelands and began to raid places in Western Europe in the 8th century CE. Most historians believe there was rapid population growth in Scandinavia during the 7th and 8th centuries, and, because of the harsh climate and rough terrain, there was limited land suitable for farming. This competition for land meant that not only was food in short supply, but local rulers began to fight among each other in order to expand their control over resources. One alternative, especially to a warrior society such as that of Scandinavia, was raiding. To the south

northeast coast of England, was pillaged by a Viking raid in 793 CE. Many of its monks were left dead. In 795 CE, monastic communities on the Scottish island of Iona, and Rathlin Island, off the northern coast of Ireland, suffered a similar fate. The situation was so bad that monks prayed for stormy weather so the “Northmen” would be unable to set sail.

The Vikings’ focus on monasteries meant that contemporary writers, all of whom were monks themselves, often portrayed them as enemies of God. They recorded the calamities that befell their brothers with genuine anguish and horror. But while the Viking attacks were vicious and ruthless, they

and their sailors highly skilled. The ships were light, with shallow bottoms, and could be sailed far inland on rivers and lakes, taken out of the water, and dragged across land to another river.

Planning to stay

The nature of Viking involvement outside Scandinavia began to change during the 9th century. At first, they began to overwinter on islands in the Seine and at the mouth of the Loire River in France. Then, in 850 CE, Charles II of France gave a group of Vikings land to settle on in exchange for aid in a conflict against his brother, Emperor Lothar. Events like this gave the Vikings influence over local power

Raiders and Traders

From the 8th to 10th centuries, Scandinavians were both the terror of Europe and its most active traders and explorers. These people swept through the treasure houses of monasteries, founded towns and cities, and even became rulers in England and France. They were called the Vikings.

lay the Carolingian empire (see pp.188–89), Anglo-Saxon England, and Ireland; all were lands divided or weakened by internal power struggles.

Lightning attacks

The first Viking raids were carried out against soft targets, such as villages and monasteries, on the coast of Frisia (Netherlands) and eastern England. Monasteries were particularly attractive to the Vikings because they were rarely fortified, and were filled with spectacular treasures donated by local Christians. The monks were unable to defend themselves, and the Vikings, who were not Christian, had no qualms about sacking the monasteries and making off with gold and silver chalices, crosses, and book covers. The monastery at Lindisfarne, on the

were not deliberately anti-Christian, as some of the records suggest.

Vikings also threatened the relatively powerful Carolingian empire in the last years of Charlemagne’s reign. His death marked a decline in central power and a rise in political instability. The Vikings exploited this power vacuum and expanded their attacks. By the 830s CE, they were able to raid the important town of Dorestad on the Rhine River three times.

Element of surprise

Early Viking raids were so effective because they struck unexpectedly. By the time locals could organize their defense, the Vikings were gone. They fought using the same basic weapons as their opponents, such as swords, spears, and axes. However, Viking longships were superior in design



Viking sword

Viking swords were often buried with their owners to accompany them on their journey to the hall of the dead warriors, Valhalla.

struggles, and encouraged them to settle outside Scandinavia. From this point on, even though they were

often involved in raids, the Vikings became much more interested in acquiring land and establishing trade. Many kingdoms paid them off with huge amounts of silver and land in order to stop attacks. Between c. 991–c. 1014, for example, the English paid 150,000 lb (68,000 kg) of silver as tribute to Scandinavian kings, a payment known as Danegeld. A band of Vikings established the Duchy of Normandy in France when a chieftain named Rollo was given Rouen and the surrounding area



Viking war spear

This spearhead was attached to a long pole, and thrown at the enemy, much the same way a modern javelin is thrown.



Viking war ax

The ax is the weapon that Vikings are most identified with. It could be wielded as a hand weapon or used for throwing.